

## CHAPTER ELEVEN

# The Toolkit Has a Limit

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— Sofia —

In December, I had a hard month.

I do not say this lightly. The whole point of being the call-Sofia kid is that, for the most part, I have not had hard months — or, the hard months I have had have been processed so quickly, with my own toolkit, that the months have not gotten to be months. They have been hard days, hard weeks. The toolkit catches the hard before the hard becomes a long thing.

December got to be a month.

I am writing this to tell you what I learned about the toolkit when it stopped working.

Here is what happened. My mom got news, in the second week of December, that her doctor was sending her to a specialist. She had had a routine mammogram in November. The mammogram had shown something. The doctor was sending her to a specialist for a biopsy. The doctor had said, in the way doctors say these things, that most of the time these turn out to be nothing, and let's not get ahead of ourselves, and I would not be alarmed yet.

My mom told me and my dad at dinner. She told us calmly. She said I want you both to know what is going on. It is probably nothing. The biopsy is in two weeks. We will know in three. Until then, life as usual. I said okay.

I did the breath. The slow one. In for four, hold for one, out for six. I did it five times, sitting at the dinner table, while my parents kept talking. I named what I was feeling. I am scared. I am scared. I love my mom. I am scared.

I did the toolkit.

The toolkit did not work.

That night I lay in bed and did the toolkit again. Slow breath. Hand on heart. I am here. I am okay. This will pass. Naming. I am scared. I am scared. I love my mom. I am scared.

The fear did not lift.

I did not sleep until almost three in the morning.

The next day at school, I was tired and the fear was still there. I did the toolkit again, in the bathroom between third and fourth period. Slow breath. Five senses walk. I looked around. I saw five things. I heard four things. I touched three things — the cold sink, my own arm, a paper towel. I smelled two things. I tasted one thing — the inside of my own mouth, which was the only thing available.

The fear did not lift.

I went to lunch. I did not tell anybody. I did not want to make it a thing. I told myself I could handle this on my own. I had been handling things on my own since I was six. I had a toolkit. I would do the toolkit. The toolkit would work.

That night I did the toolkit again. It did not work.

The next night. The toolkit. It did not work.

By the end of the first week, I had not slept more than five hours a night since the dinner conversation.

I had also, by the end of that week, been keeping the fear secret, which I now realize was the bigger problem. I had been the call-Sofia kid for so long that I had not developed, for myself, the practice of being the kid who calls somebody else. I did not have a call-Sofia of my own. I had Mia, of course —

Mia, in Pittsburgh, who had been my person from far away since we were nine. But Mia was, in some unspoken way, my friend-from-childhood and I did not want to load her with a thing that had not even been diagnosed yet. I told myself I would tell Mia after the biopsy results came back.

I also had my parents. But the fear was about my parents. I could not exactly take it to my parents.

I had the cohort. But I was — and this is the bad pattern, the one I did not know I was in — I was so used to being the cohort's listener that I did not know how to flip the script. To say, hi, this week I am the one who needs to be listened to.

I was, in some real sense, trapped inside my own identity as the listener.

The toolkit, by itself, was not designed to handle a week-long scare that I was not letting myself talk about. The toolkit was designed for daily hard feelings — for things you can name and address and put down

within a few hours. The toolkit, used alone, on a thing that big, did not work.

What worked, finally, was that Amara noticed.

Amara, on a Thursday afternoon during a free block, sat down across from me in the senior lounge and said, very directly:

Sof. You look terrible. What is going on.

I said nothing.

She said Sof.

I said I am tired.

She said Sof.

I said Amara.

She said Sof. Tell me. Right now.

I cried. In the senior lounge. For the first time, I think, in school, in maybe two years.

She moved over. She put her arm around my shoulder. She did not say anything for a long time. She let me cry. She knew, in the way Amara knows things, that whatever was going on was bigger than something the lounge could fix in fifteen minutes.

When I could talk, I told her. I told her about my mom. I told her about the biopsy in two weeks. I told her about the probably nothing. I told her I had not slept in five nights. I told her I had been doing the toolkit and the toolkit had not worked.

Amara listened.

When I was done, she said:

Sof. The toolkit is not designed for this. The toolkit, used alone, does not handle a week of pre-news-fear about your mother. The toolkit, used alone, is not a substitute for telling somebody. You have been keeping this inside. You are exhausted because the inside-keeping is the part that is making you tired. The fear, by itself, would not have made you this tired. The fear plus the keeping made you this tired.

I said I know.

She said Sof. I am going to be the person you tell. About this. Through this. I am going to be the call-Amara for the call-Sofia kid. Through the whole biopsy and the whole results and the whole thing. You are going to text me every day until we have results. You are going to text me about what you are feeling. You do not have to be the call-Sofia kid right now.

You get to be the kid who calls Amara. Okay?

I cried again.

I said okay.

I texted her every day for the next two weeks. She texted back. Sometimes the texts were long. Sometimes they were

short. Sometimes they were just I am here. Today is a hard day. I am here.

I slept better starting the second night after Amara and I talked. The biopsy came back benign. My mom is fine. The doctor was right that most of the time these turn out to be nothing. My mom is taking some extra screenings going forward but the news was the good news. I cried, when my mom told us. I cried in relief. I cried also, I now realize, in the recognition of how heavy the carrying had been. I also cried, separately, when I told Amara the result. Amara cried with me. She said Sof. I am so glad. I am so glad.

We had a small private graduation-from-fear moment between us. Here is what I learned, in December.

The toolkit is real and it works for most things. It does not work, by itself, for big things. For big things, the toolkit is step one — the slow breath, the naming, the hand on the heart — and then the rest of the toolkit is other people. The trusted adult. The friend. The therapist. The big tools.

I had, for a long time, been treating the toolkit as if it was a solo practice. As if the goal was to be self-sufficient. As if needing other people would have meant the toolkit had failed.

The toolkit, I now realize, has never been a solo practice. The trusted adult was always in the toolkit. The friend was always in the toolkit. I had been using the smaller tools and not the bigger ones. The bigger ones were always there.

I am, I now realize, going to be a therapist someday partly because I have, in my own life, just learned what therapists already know: no one does this work alone, and the people who try to do it alone are the ones who burn out. The healthy way is to do it together. The healthy way is to call somebody. The healthy way is to let yourself be the kid who needs help,

sometimes, instead of always being the kid who gives it. I told this to Mia, after.

Mia said, Sof. Welcome to the club. Some of us have been doing the let myself need help practice for a long time. You are the last of us to figure it out, because you have been so good at the other thing. The you who lets people in is going to be a better therapist than the you who did it alone would have been. I promise.

I told Ms. Calloway about it too, in our Capstone block one Friday in early January, in the small private way Ms. Calloway lets you tell her things by hanging back at the end of class.

Ms. Calloway said, Sofia. This is one of the most important things you are going to learn in your whole life. You learned it at seventeen. Most therapists do not learn it until they are thirty and burning out. You are ahead. You are way ahead.

She gave me a hug. She does not usually hug seniors. She hugged me. I went home.

I am writing this in my own notebook, in early January. The fear about my mom is in the past, for now. The bigger lesson — about the toolkit, about who gets in, about who I am willing to call — is going forward. The toolkit has been updated.

The toolkit, version eighteen, includes Amara. And Mia. And my parents. And Ms. Calloway, when I really need her. And — when I am a therapist someday — it will include the therapist I will see, regularly, the way good therapists see other therapists. That is what we call supervision, in the field. I learned the word from AP Psych. I will need supervision. Everybody who does this work needs supervision. I am, in January of senior year, eighteen years old and revising the most important thing I have built in my life. I am revising it to include being supported, not just supporting.

I am proud of me.

I am — for the first time, in some honest way — getting what self-compassion means. Self-compassion is not just being kind to myself when I have made a mistake. Self-compassion is also letting other people be kind to me when I am scared.

I have been letting other people be kind to me, this winter, for the first time.

It feels — and I want to write this down so I do not forget — it feels good.

Self-compassion is not solitary.

That is the lesson.

— Sofia